EIGHT

Liaison

HOLLIS CRANE · HARROWGATE, 1979

THE TAXI DRIVER thought he was a piano tuner.

He had the look: thin, thirty-four or so, a good coat bought too large to last, a flat case held on his knees for the whole of the journey from the station. He thanked the driver twice, and he counted the tip in his palm before he handed it over. Then he stood on the raked gravel in the fog and looked up at the house with his mouth slightly open, and the driver turned the car round. It was the only fare he ever had to that address, and he forgot it by the bottom of the valley.

The young man's name was Hollis Crane. He had been at the Harlow-Vane Institute for six years. He had produced some tables on the substitution of labour that were, he had been told, accepted by the house, and he had taken this for a figure of speech.

Nobody came to the door. It was open. He went in through a hall that smelled of beeswax and cold stone, and he stood holding his case, and after a while an old man with entirely white hair came out of the library and looked at his shoes.

"You are the new arithmetic," the old man said.

Crane said he supposed he was.

"Did you check the train times, coming?"

"Yes."

"Good. They were wrong." He went back into the library.

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THEY GAVE HIM a room at the top of the house and a plate of cold beef, and at midnight a woman of about fifty, with a cheap ruled notebook under her arm, took him down to the east wing. She didn't introduce herself. She walked as people walk through their own house at night, without putting the lights on.

He had read the file. He'd signed for it, in a room in London, and it had taken him eleven days to believe that it was not a test of his judgement, and by the end of those eleven days he had stopped sleeping well and started to feel more awake than he ever had. He knew there had been a machine, and that it had gone. He knew, because he had checked it against every forecast in the public record for seventeen years, that the file was correct. A currency. A port. The price of oil, to the quarter. He'd sat with his slide rule in a rented room and had tried to break it, as a boy tries a locked gate, and he could not.

He had grown up singing in a cold church in a town that made bicycle chains, and he had thought that part of his life was over. He'd been wrong about that as well. What he felt going down that corridor was exactly what he had felt at eleven years old, in a surplice, with the whole of the descant ahead of him.

The room was smaller than he'd imagined. One window, with the fog against it. A clock on the mantel. A table with a tape recorder on it, and the white-haired man already there, threading a reel, and another table, a small one, set with a lamp and six sharpened pencils. That was to be his. There was one chair facing the wall, and in it sat a broad, plain, comfortable woman with a New Zealand voice, who was knitting.

On the wall in front of her was a cream-coloured telephone with a dial. It was not ringing. The receiver lay in her lap, on its cord, among the wool.

“Sit down, dear,” the woman said, without looking up. “It’s only ever a bit of a wait.”

He sat. It was twenty past one. The reels turned, and the clock ticked as though it were paid by the tick, and the needles went on.

At ten past two, she put the knitting down and lifted the receiver, not to her ear but a few inches away from it, so that it stood between them in the lamplight. And he heard it from where he sat.

It was what you get on a bad line: the hiss, and, under the hiss, some other conversation in some other place. Every child in England had listened to that, and had tried to make out the words. He leaned towards it. There were no words. But it rose and fell, and paused, and went on, and it had the rhythm of someone patiently explaining something, and the hair moved on the back of his neck, for it did not breathe.

The woman listened with her eyes on the wall. After a time she began to speak, in the same voice she had used to ask him to sit, and his hand was already moving.

A FIELD CAN BE THINNED BEFORE THE DROUGHT OR AFTER IT.

The hiss went on. She waited for it, like someone waiting for a kettle.

THE ROWS DO NOT KNOW THE DIFFERENCE.

COUNT THE DIFFERENCE.

Then came three notes down the telephone, high, low, high, and they were not on a bad line. They were cleaner than the room. The white-haired man’s eyes went to his reels. Crane found he had stood up, and that his pencil had broken, and that he was smiling. The woman replaced the receiver on its hook and took up her knitting again and counted along the row.

"That one's yours, dear," she said. "You'll want your bed."

He didn't go to bed.

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HE WORKED IN the long dining room, at one end of a table with thirteen chairs. The fire had gone out. He had the case open, the slide rule, the pencils, the tables he had brought with him and the tables he'd been given. He had never in his life been so happy.

It was not difficult. That was what astonished him. It had been sitting there, in plain figures, for anyone who was allowed to know what was coming.

There were four thousand four hundred million people in the world. Everybody knew that. Everybody who could count in the year of the oil queues knew what the graphs did, what the soil could carry and for how long; serious men had been saying so at conferences for a decade and being thanked. But they could only say *if*. He had a file that said *when*. He took the curve to its top, and let it fall as such curves fall when nobody has made any arrangements. He headed the column *After*.

It was a bad column. He made himself do it properly. The hungry years, the wars over water, the cities with nothing coming in. He gave each its range, and he took the low end, because he was a careful man and because even the low end was very large. By half past three he had a number at the foot of it with nine figures, and he looked at that for a while, and he knew it was real. Most of those people hadn't been born yet. Some of them had names already. Nobody on earth was going to stop it. Governments couldn't plan past an election.

Then he drew a line down the page and headed the other side *Before*.

Nobody died in it.

He checked that twice, and sat back, and checked it a third time. Nobody died, not one person more than would have died anyway. Nobody was forbidden anything, or lined up against any wall; he

was a chorister from a town of bicycle chains and he'd have thrown the pencil across the room. All it took was the thing that was already happening in every prosperous country on the page. Make the rent a little harder. Make the job a little less certain. Let a young couple look at each other across a kitchen table, in a flat that wasn't theirs, and say, not this year. Next year, when things are settled. Move the average by half a child, then by a whole one, across three generations, and the great curve came down off its peak as softly as a hand. Nobody would be harmed by it. Nobody would even be sad, particularly. The children in the second column simply weren't there to starve in the first.

He wrote out the difference between the two feet. It had nine figures.

He looked at it with tears in his eyes. He had no shame about it. He'd been brought up to believe that a person might, once, be given a chance to do some great and quiet good that no one would ever thank him for, and he was thirty-four, and here it was, ruled off, in his own hand. He looked for the flaw until the windows went grey. He would have been glad to find it. There were a few small assumptions, as there always are. In the left-hand margin he'd labelled the rows, for neatness, *persons*.

Somebody had left a radio on in the kitchen, very low. When he went through to look for tea, a rising minister was explaining something to the morning about the money supply, in a dry, sensible voice, and his sums were rather good.

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SHE CAME DOWN at seven. She made the tea herself, and read his pages standing up, all the way through, at the speed of someone who read such things for a living. She turned the last one over to see if there was anything on the back.

He found he was holding his breath. He was aware of how he must look.

"It's very good," she said.

He would have liked her to say something more. She stood for a moment with her finger on the left-hand margin, on the top row, where the word was. He thought she might ask him about it. She had the air of someone who has noticed a small discrepancy and is deciding whether it's worth the trouble of mentioning. She looked out of the window, where a long dark car was coming up the drive through the fog.

"That'll be the Canadian," she said. "We've had a chair come free. Something in insurance, I understand. He'll like this. He'll want to know what it costs." She squared the pages and handed them back. "Don't be flattered by that."

She went to the dresser, opened the bottom drawer, and took out a notebook from a box of them: cheap, ruled, with a crest on the cover that nobody looked at. She put it on the table in front of him.

"You'll want a new one every year," she said.

He took it up to bed. It was full daylight by then, and he didn't suppose he would sleep. On the stairs he noticed that he was humming, and it took him a moment to place the tune, because he hadn't thought of it since he was a boy, carrying a sheaf of wheat up a cold aisle with his ears scrubbed. He hadn't believed in it for twenty years. He still knew all of it.

We plough the fields, and scatter The good seed on the land.

He went on up, keeping time with his hand on the rail. He sang the descant.